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### How tradition can become tragedy

Every June 27th, the villagers gather in the square, children laugh, neighbors chat, and the morning sun shines on an ordinary American town, until someone is beaten to death with rocks. Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery" opens with a lie: the lie of normalcy. Beneath its cheerful surface, the story conceals one of literature's most devastating revelations about human nature: that ordinary people, good neighbors and loving parents, are fully capable of ritualized murder simply because tradition tells them it is the right thing to do. Through control of setting, plot structure, and literary technique, Jackson constructs a trap for the reader that mirrors the trap society sets for its own members. Her central argument is its simplicity: blind obedience to tradition does not require monsters, because people are already sufficient.

To understand how Jackson builds this trap, it helps to start with the title and setting. "The Lottery" is a word that usually carries a promise of reward, yet Jackson exploits that promise ruthlessly, as readers expect a winner, not a corpse. This misdirection produces what can be called an epiphany, a sudden and total rewriting of everything the reader thought they understood. When the stones are finally thrown, the whole village is shone with a terrifying new light. The setting also deepens this effect considerably. In particular, the story takes place on a bright June morning in what is clearly a mid-twentieth-century American town, where men discuss "planting and rain, tractors and taxes" (Jackson). Yet the ritual unfolding in the square belongs to something far older and darker, closer to a

medieval sacrifice than a modern event. Jackson places these two worlds side by side on purpose. The tractors and the stoning exist in the same afternoon, in the same sunlight, among the same smiling neighbors. Her point is uncomfortable: modernity is only a surface. Beneath it, the primitive violence has never left.

The plot structure of the story is also engineered with similar precision to create and sustain tension. In the exposition, Jackson introduces the village with a calm and pleasant hand. Children run freely, neighbors chat, and the day feels like a holiday. But foreshadowing quietly poisons the warmth. Bobby Martin stuffs his pockets with stones, and the boys construct "a great pile of stones in one corner" (Jackson). On the surface, this means children playing. Looking back after finishing the story, it became the preparation of weapons. Jackson trusts the reader to feel the unease before they can name it.

The rising action begins with Mr. Summers' arrival with the black box and the lottery drawing. Jackson narrates all of this in a third-person point of view, reporting only what characters do and say, never what they think or feel. This restraint is one of the story's most important choices. Because the reader cannot enter any character's inner life, the villagers appear cheerful, cooperative, and utterly normal, which is precisely what makes them so frightening. The prose style reinforces this effect. Jackson's diction is plain, and her pace is slow, luring the reader into the trap that she prepared.

Conflict arises when Bill Hutchinson draws the marked slip, and his wife Tessie immediately begins to protest. Tessie functions as the story's protagonist, the figure through whom the reader feels the horror of the ritual. Yet, the true antagonist is not a single villain. It is the tradition itself, something the village has built around an act of murder and called culture. Tessie cries out that Bill was not given enough time to choose his paper fairly, and the men in charge dismiss her completely. As Hall argues, this moment exposes the deeply patriarchal structure of the village, where male authority goes unchallenged and a woman's objection, no matter how desperate, carries no weight (Hall). Tessie is not simply

outvoted. She is not heard at all. With that, Jackson makes clear that the lottery's violence is not only physical but also built into the social order that surrounds it.

Tessie's protest is more revealing because she only objects when she becomes the victim. She is not challenging the lottery on moral grounds. She is complaining that the draw was conducted unfairly against her family. She accepted the tradition completely until it turned against her. This is one of Jackson's sharpest observations: people rarely question a system until they become its victim, and even then, they tend to argue about procedure rather than purpose.

The falling action moves with a surprising speed. The Hutchinson family draws again, the papers are opened, and the resolution arrives without ceremony. Tessie unfolds the slip with the black spot, and the village surrounds her. Her final words, "It isn't fair, it isn't right" (Jackson), are the most important in the story, not because they change anything, but because they change nothing. The community, including her own children, picks up the stones and carries out the sentence. The conflict is resolved the way it always has been, with total obedience and no questioning.

Throughout all of this, Jackson also uses various literary devices to reinforce her argument about tradition. The black wooden box is the story's central symbol. Rotting, splintered, barely holding together, it is described as having "original wood color" (Jackson) showing through where the paint has worn away. The village refuses to replace it, not out of reverence for the box itself but out of a fear of changing anything related to the ritual. The box is a symbol of the tradition it contains: deteriorating, purposeless, and stubborn. This connects directly to the story's theme, that communities will defend broken traditions simply because abandoning them feels more dangerous than continuing them.

Jackson also employs a brief flashback to explain the box's origins, tracing it back to "the first people" (Jackson) who settled the village. This gesture reaches backward to give the tradition the fake legitimacy. Paired with this is something closer to a flash forward, delivered through Old Man Warner, who warns that abandoning the lottery will send civilization back to "living in caves" (Jackson) and eating

"stewed chickweed and acorns" (Jackson). His logic is the logic of every society that has ever committed an atrocity in the name of order, that stopping the ritual will break everything apart. Jackson frames this belief with quiet irony. Warner is the village's most passionate defender of a tradition, yet he cannot explain or has never examined.

On the level of language, Jackson uses figurative language effectively. When Tessie arrives late to the square and makes a joke, " (Jackson) soft laughter ran through the crowd". The laughter is described as a physical thing moving through bodies, bringing the group together. It is a small detail, but it does important work. The crowd is not a collection of individuals in this moment. It is a single organism, and its gentleness is as disturbing as its violence because both come from the same source.

In conclusion, "The Lottery" earns its reputation as one of American literature's most enduring and unsettling stories because every element of its craft serves a coherent argument. The plot structure builds a perfect trap. The setting creates a collision between the comfortable and the brutal. The symbolism, the point of view, the restrained prose style, all of them make the reader feel, rather than simply understand, how ordinary people sustain cruelty. Tessie Hutchinson does not die because her neighbors are evil. She dies because no one, including Tessie herself, thought to ask why the lottery existed in the first place. That is the lesson Jackson leaves behind, quiet but worth thinking about: traditions may not be the truth, and questioning them may be the wise thing to do.

Works Cited

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